

BEARS

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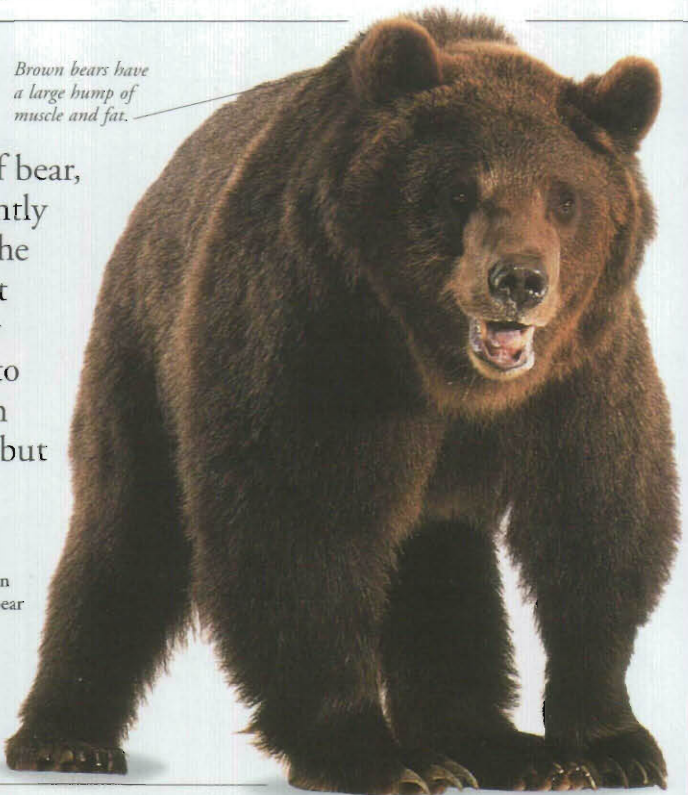


THERE ARE SEVEN different species of bear, plus the giant panda which has recently been classified as a primitive bear. The polar and brown bears are the largest meat-eating land animals alive today. All bears rely heavily on their acute senses of smell and hearing to find food and to locate predators. Bears that live in cool climates hibernate in dens during the winter, but those in warmer areas are active all year round.

Brown bears

There are nine subspecies of brown bear. The largest is the Kodiak bear found on islands in Alaska. It may stand 3.5 m (12 ft) tall on its hind legs and is one of the most powerful animals in North America. The grizzly bear, also of North America, has white-tipped fur, giving it a "grizzled" look. The other brown bears live in Europe and temperate Asia.

North American brown bear



Brown bears have a large hump of muscle and fat.



Large canine teeth and powerful jaws

Fishing

Bears of North America have a rich source of salmon when the fish swim up rivers to spawn. The bears may stand in the water and catch fish in the air as they leap up a waterfall.



Asian black bear feeding

Diet

Bears belong to the order of mammals called carnivores, meaning meat-eaters. They catch and kill other animals for food and eat carrion, but they will take almost any kind of food they can find, including insects. About three-quarters of most bears' diet is plant material, such as fruits, nuts, roots, and shoots.

Paws

There are five clawed toes on a bear's paws. The animals use their forepaws to gather food and manipulate small food items. They can kill another animal with one blow from a paw, or use their long claws to dig up roots, and open insects' nests.



Kermodes bear

Most American black bears are black, but some are brown, beige, or blue-black. Small isolated populations of white black bears, called Kermodes bears, live on the coast of British Columbia, Canada.

Types of bear



Sloth bear A long-coated bear from India and Sri Lanka, the sloth bear eats mainly termites, which it sucks up through its lips.

Sun bear This bear from south-eastern Asia is the smallest bear. It has short, dense fur, with a yellow mark on its chest. It has a long tongue with which it licks up ants and termites.



Polar bear This white-coated bear is the most carnivorous, eating mainly seals and fish. It lives on the Arctic coast.

Brown bear This bear lives across the northern hemisphere, but in small populations only. It has disappeared from many areas.



Shaggy black fur



Spectacled bear The only South American bear, this rare animal lives on the wooded slopes of the Andes. It eats mostly plant material, especially fruit, but will eat meat if it is available.



A crescent of white fur accounts for this bear's other name of moon bear.

Asian black bear An agile climber, this bear lives in woods of south-eastern Asia, from Afghanistan to China and Japan.



American black bear Found across North America, this bear will raid tents, cars, and dustbins for food.

Cubs' games are practice for adult conflicts.



Cubs

A female bear gives birth to her cubs in a den, where she stays with them for up to two or three months. Each litter usually contains one to three cubs, which are born helpless and weigh only a tiny percentage of their mother's weight. They develop quickly but will stay with their mother until nearly full-grown. This may be for as long as two or three years in the case of the larger bears. Female bears make good mothers and will defend their cubs ferociously.

GRIZZLY BEAR

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Ursus arctos horribilis*

ORDER Carnivora

FAMILY Ursidae

DISTRIBUTION Northwestern North America

HABITAT Mountains, forests, wilderness

DIET Almost anything, including berries, leaves, roots, small animals, fish, and carrion

SIZE Length: 1.8–2.8 m (6–9 ft)
Weight: 160–230 kg (350–500 lb)

LIFESPAN 25–30 years

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